

# Coleraine Driving Test

## Complete Survival Guide

A practical, visual handbook for calm decisions, clean observations and safe driving under test pressure.

**12**

FOCUSED PARTS

**40 min**

APPROXIMATE DRIVE

**1 goal**

SAFE, LEGAL, INDEPENDENT

**Prepared August 2026.**

This is an independent study aid, not an official DVA publication. Road layouts, signs and test procedures can change. Your appointment letter, live signs/markings and your Approved Driving Instructor always take priority.

# How to use this guide

1

Read the core routines

2

Practise one situation

3

Debrief the drive

4

Use the cheat sheet

## Do this

- Read Parts 1–2 once.
- Before each lesson, choose one situation card.
- Say the hazards and plan aloud with your instructor.
- Afterwards, write one trigger and one better action.

## Do not do this

- Do not memorise an alleged test route.
- Do not force a turn because an instruction was late.
- Do not treat the speed limit as a target.
- Do not replace instructor-led practice with this guide.

### Three corrections to the outline you supplied

In Northern Ireland, independent driving does **not** use sat-nav. The current DVA car test uses one reversing exercise from reversing around a corner, turning in the road, or reverse parking on-road/into a bay; it also includes an emergency stop. Forward bay parking and pulling up on the right are useful skills but are not listed by DVA as the set NI reversing exercises.

## The pressure rule

When uncertain, keep the car safe and legal first. A wrong direction is not automatically a fault. A sudden lane change, unsafe gap or missed red light can be.

### Say this to yourself

“I can miss the turn. I cannot miss the hazard.”

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# How the Northern Ireland test works

## Before driving

Eyesight check: read a registration plate at the required distance. If unsuccessful, the drive does not continue.

## Safety checks

One “show me” and one “tell me” vehicle-safety question. One driving fault is recorded if one or both answers are wrong.

## On the road

About 40 minutes, typical roads and traffic, one reversing exercise, emergency stop and a section of independent driving.

## What the examiner is really assessing

| Area        | What good looks like                                             | What creates risk                                                           |
|-------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Observation | Checks are timely, targeted and acted upon.                      | Looking without responding; missing a vulnerable road user.                 |
| Control     | Smooth steering, speed and pedals while maintaining observation. | Loss of control, coasting, harsh or late inputs.                            |
| Planning    | Early reading of signs, markings, gaps and developing hazards.   | Last-second braking, lane changes or indecision.                            |
| Judgement   | Safe gaps without unnecessary delay.                             | Making another road user brake/change course, or repeated undue hesitation. |
| Progress    | Appropriate speed and confident movement when safe.              | Driving too fast for conditions or holding up traffic without reason.       |

### Pass standard

DVA states that up to 15 driving faults can still result in a pass; 16 or more means a fail. One serious or dangerous fault means a fail. Do not count faults during the drive—keep driving safely.

# Faults, mistakes and recovery

## Driving fault

A lapse that is not potentially dangerous in that instance. Repetition can show a pattern and become serious.

## Serious fault

A fault with the potential to be dangerous, or a serious breach of the expected standard.

## Dangerous fault

Actual danger to you, the examiner, the public or property. The test may be stopped if the examiner considers you a danger.

## Examiner action

Verbal or physical intervention is powerful evidence of risk, but the classification depends on the full circumstances.

## The 10-second recovery

1

**Stabilise**

steer, speed, space. Finish the immediate task safely.

2

**Breathe**

one slow exhale. Release your grip and shoulders.

3

**Scan**

mirrors, road ahead, signs and next hazard.

4

**Reset**

say “new road, new plan.” Do not replay the event.

### Never self-fail

You cannot reliably classify a fault while driving. A stall, wrong turn or imperfect manoeuvre may be minor—or no fault at all—if managed safely.

# Independent driving—without sat-nav

The examiner may ask you to follow traffic signs, up to three verbal directions supported by a diagram, or a combination. DVA explicitly says sat-nav cannot be used because independent driving requires your own decisions.

## Before it starts

- Listen to the full instruction.
- Repeat it once if useful.
- Ask for clarification while stationary.
- Identify the first decision only.

## While driving

- Scan direction signs early.
- Keep normal MSPSL routines.
- Ask for confirmation if genuinely unsure.
- Prioritise a safe lane over the requested route.

### SITUATION

## You miss an independent-driving turn

### 1 • BEFORE

- Check mirrors and continue in your current safe lane.
- Cancel any misleading signal.

### 2 • APPROACH

- Do not brake sharply or cut across lanes.
- Tell the examiner briefly: "I've missed that turn."

### 3 • DURING

- Follow the road safely.
- Listen for help to rejoin the route.

### 4 • EXIT / FINISH

- Rebuild your plan from the next sign.
- Return to normal progress.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Forcing the turn

✗ Stopping in a live lane

✗ Dwelling on the mistake

**GOLDEN RULE** A wrong route is not a fault unless the driving used to take it is faulty.

# “Show me / tell me” revision

Wording can vary and controls differ by car. Practise in the exact test vehicle. Never operate a control unless it is safe.

## Know how to show

- Direction indicators and hazard lights
- Brake lights (explain use of reflections or assistance)
- Horn, when appropriate and stationary
- Windscreen wash/wipe
- Front/rear demisters
- Dipped/main-beam headlights and warning lamp
- Rear fog light and when it should be used
- Parking brake and service brake operation
- Power-assisted steering check

## Know how to tell

- Tyre pressure: handbook/label, reliable gauge, cold tyres, valve caps, spare if fitted
- Tyre condition: no cuts/bulges; legal tread across the required breadth and circumference
- Head restraint: rigid part roughly level with eyes/top of ears and close to head
- ABS warning-light check
- Engine oil: dipstick or vehicle system, level ground, engine procedure
- Coolant: reservoir min/max when cold; never open hot
- Brake fluid and washer-fluid reservoirs
- Lights and reflectors: clean, secure and working

## Under the bonnet

Be able to identify the oil, coolant, brake-fluid and screen-wash locations in your car and explain the check. You will not be asked to touch a hot engine or physically check fluid levels.

## Answer formula

**Identify** → **method** → **safe condition** → **expected result**. Example: “I would identify the coolant expansion tank, check the level against MIN/MAX when the engine is cold, and top up with the correct mixture only as described in the handbook.”

# Test-day checklist

## Bring

- ☐ Appointment letter
- ☐ Both parts of your NI photocard driving licence (check your letter)
- ☐ Valid MOT certificate
- ☐ Theory-test pass certificate or confirmation if required
- ☐ Glasses/contact lenses if needed
- ☐ Any recall evidence required for the vehicle

## Vehicle

- ☐ Appropriately insured, licensed and roadworthy
- ☐ Clearly visible L-plates front and rear
- ☐ Passenger seatbelt and integral head restraint
- ☐ Interior mirror for examiner—not a visor mirror
- ☐ Working lights, tyres and warning lamps
- ☐ Fuel/charge and clean windows/mirrors

### Use your appointment letter as the authority

Document requirements can depend on your licence and booking. DVA warns that missing required items can mean no test and loss of the fee.

## Night-before vehicle sweep

| Outside                             | Inside                                            | Admin                                               |
|-------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| Tyres, lights, plates, glass, leaks | Seat/mirrors, warning lights, demisters, controls | Documents, insurance, route to centre, arrival time |



# The core routine: MSPSL



Mirrors



Signal



Position



Speed



Look

## Mirrors

Check the mirrors that answer a question.  
Slowing: interior, then relevant side mirror.  
Turning/changing lane: interior plus the side you will move toward.

## Signal

Signal only when it helps. Give it in good time, but not so early that it misleads. Cancel after the manoeuvre.

## Position

Choose the correct lane and road position early. Preserve space from kerbs, parked cars and vulnerable users.

## Speed

Reduce early enough to observe and stop. Select a suitable gear before the hazard where possible.

## Look

Assess the junction, gap, crossing and escape space continuously. Looking is not enough—you must respond to what you see.

### MSPSL is a thinking routine

It is not a theatrical sequence. Checks must be timely and connected to a decision.

# Mirrors, blind spots and planning

| Change           | Minimum useful check                                                          | Reason                                            |
|------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| Slow or stop     | Interior; relevant side if moving toward kerb                                 | Know what follows and avoid surprising them.      |
| Turn left/right  | Interior + left/right door mirror                                             | Check cycles, motorcycles and overtaking traffic. |
| Change lane      | Interior + target-side mirror + effective sideways/blind-spot check as needed | Confirm the target space is clear.                |
| Move off         | All-round observation, including blind spot                                   | Detect anyone the mirrors cannot show.            |
| Pass obstruction | Interior + right mirror before moving out; interior + left before returning   | Protect both lateral moves.                       |
| Exit roundabout  | Interior + left mirror before signalling/moving left                          | Check for a vehicle or cycle alongside.           |

## Observation quality

### Early

Enough time to change your plan.

### Relevant

The mirror/blind spot for the direction of movement.

### Acted on

Delay, change speed or abandon the move if needed.

### Avoid mirror theatre

Rapid head flicks that do not collect information are not effective observation. Brief, clear checks with eyes returning promptly to the road are safer.

# Speed, space, signals and position

| Road/vehicle                       | Car maximum unless signs say otherwise | Remember                                                 |
|------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| Built-up road with street lights   | Usually 30 mph                         | 20 mph limits are common; look for terminal signs.       |
| Single carriageway, national limit | 60 mph                                 | Single means no central reservation—not number of lanes. |
| Dual carriageway, national limit   | 70 mph                                 | Dual means a central reservation separates directions.   |
| Any signed lower limit             | Signed value                           | Be at the new lower limit by the sign.                   |

## Too fast

- Cannot stop in distance seen clear
- Rushes junction observation
- Reduces clearance margin
- Turns a small error serious

## Too slow

- Unjustifiably holds traffic
- Misses safe gaps repeatedly
- Shows poor limit recognition
- Encourages risky overtakes

### Maximum ≠ target

Choose the speed that lets you stop within the distance you can see to be clear, adjusted for people, surface, visibility and available space.

# T-junctions, STOP and poor visibility

## SITUATION Emerging from a side road

### 1 · BEFORE

- Read STOP/GIVE WAY signs and markings.
- Interior mirror; identify pedestrians and cycles.
- Choose safe approach position.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Slow early; select a responsive gear.
- Stop if required or if the view demands it.
- Keep wheels under control; avoid rolling.

### 3 · DURING

- Look right–left–right and keep scanning.
- Judge both gap and vehicle speed.
- Move only without making others change course/speed.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Accelerate appropriately.
- Straighten and check mirrors.
- Build speed if conditions allow.

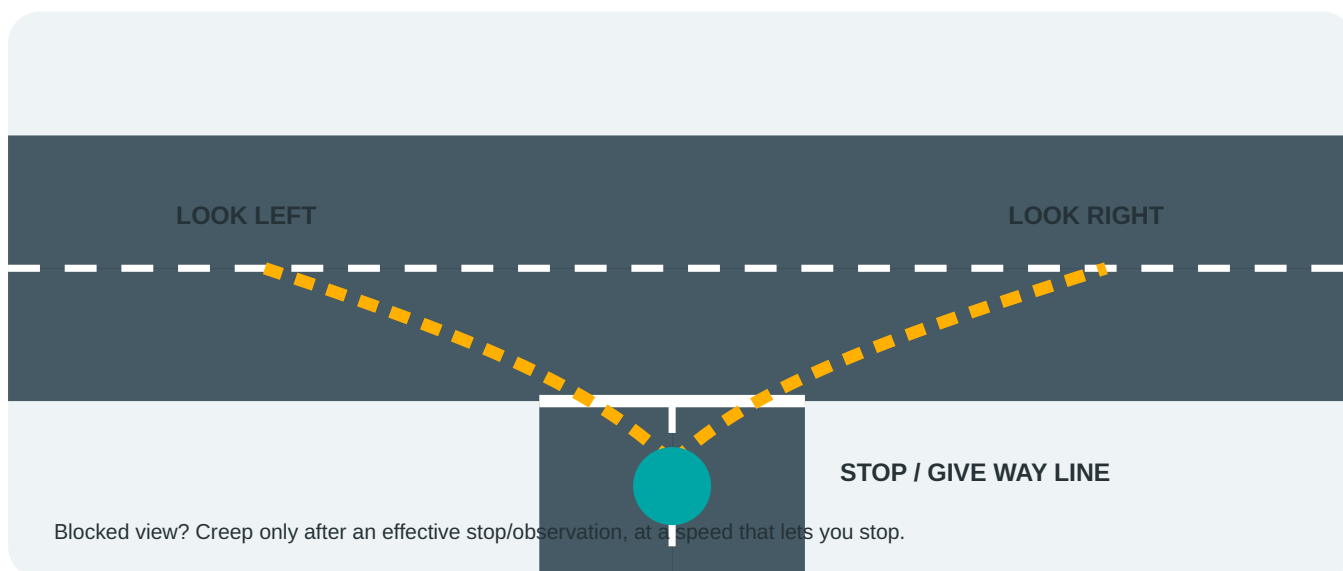
### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Looking only once

✗ Nose entering too far

✗ Accepting a gap under pressure

**GOLDEN RULE** If you cannot see, you cannot safely go.



# Major-to-minor turns

## SITUATION Turning right from a major road

### 1 · BEFORE

- Interior and right mirror.
- Signal in good time.
- Check road markings and oncoming traffic.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Position toward centre without crossing it.
- Reduce speed early.
- Keep the junction mouth clear if waiting.

### 3 · DURING

- Give way to oncoming traffic and crossing pedestrians.
- Look into the new road before turning.
- Turn when the gap is safe; do not cut the corner.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Enter the correct side of the new road.
- Cancel signal; mirrors.
- Progress when clear.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Cutting corner

✗ Wheels turned while waiting in exposed position

✗ Focusing only on oncoming cars

**GOLDEN RULE** Look into the road you are entering before the steering begins.

## SITUATION Turning left from a major road

### 1 · BEFORE

- Interior and left mirror—check for cycles.
- Signal if useful.
- Check the new road and crossing.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Move to normal left position, not over the kerb.
- Slow enough for the view and radius.

### 3 · DURING

- Give way to pedestrians crossing the road you enter.
- Keep checking the left side.
- Follow the kerb without swinging right.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Straighten; cancel signal.
- Mirrors and appropriate progress.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Late left-mirror check

✗ Swinging wide

✗ Rushing past pedestrians

**GOLDEN RULE** Slow enough to see and protect the nearside.

# Lights, crossings and box junctions

## Traffic lights

- **Red:** stop behind the line.
- **Red + amber:** still stop; prepare.
- **Green:** proceed only if the way is clear.
- **Amber:** stop unless already over the line or so close that stopping could cause a collision.
- **Green arrow:** move only in its direction if clear.

## Yellow box

- Do not enter unless your exit is clear.
- Exception: you may enter to turn right and wait only because of oncoming traffic or other right-turners.
- Do not follow traffic blindly into the box.
- Look beyond the vehicle ahead before crossing the line.

### SITUATION Lights turn amber as you approach

#### 1 · BEFORE

- Check interior mirror as part of your approach.
- Know speed, distance and following traffic.

#### 2 · APPROACH

- If you can stop normally before the line, stop.
- Do not accelerate to “beat” amber.

#### 3 · DURING

- If already across or too close to stop safely, continue with care.
- Check the junction remains clear.

#### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Clear it without racing.
- Re-establish mirrors and speed.

#### COMMON MISTAKES

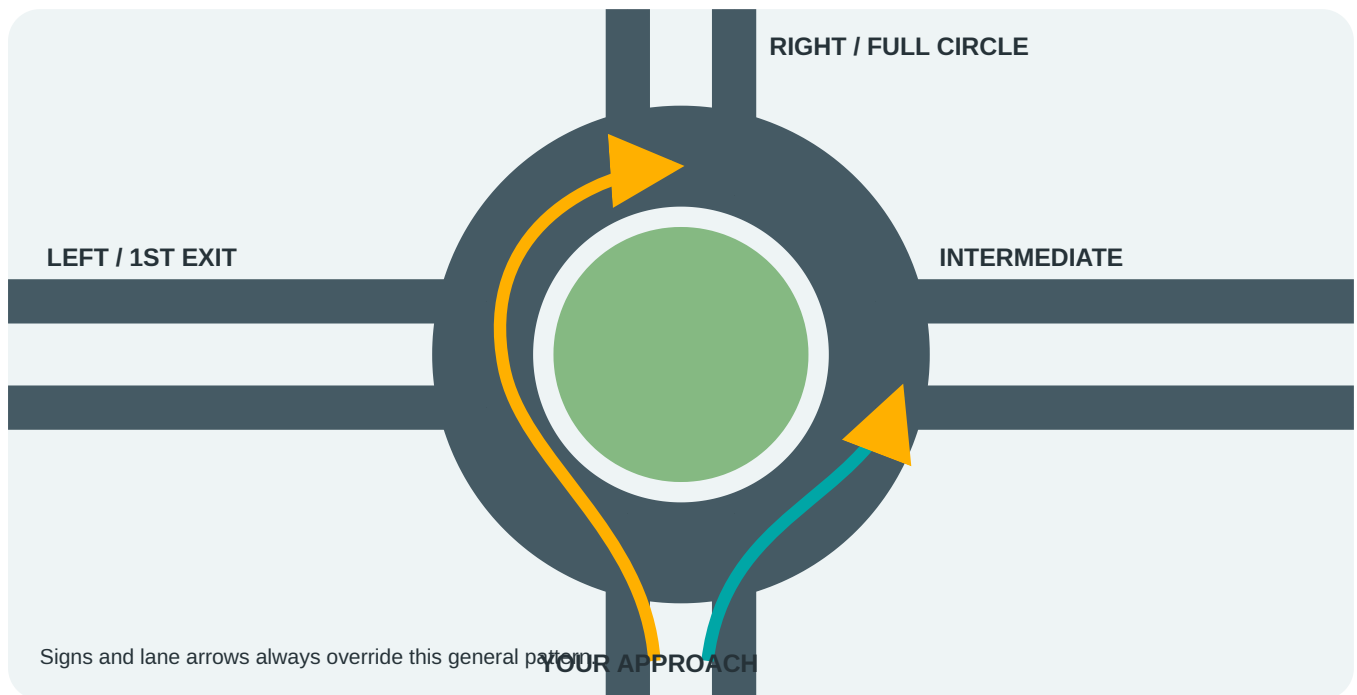
✗ Harsh avoidable stop

✗ Crossing after red

✗ Watching the light but not the junction

**GOLDEN RULE** Amber means stop—except when stopping safely is no longer realistic.

# Roundabout fundamentals



## First exit left

Unless signs/markings say otherwise: left lane, signal left, keep left and continue the signal to exit.

## Intermediate

Select the marked/appropriate lane; normally no approach signal. Signal left after passing the exit before yours.

## Right/full circle

Unless directed otherwise: right lane and right signal; signal left after the exit before yours, checking before moving left.

### Order of authority

**Traffic lights and police/traffic control → signs → road markings → general roundabout routine.**  
Never cling to a memorised lane when the live markings say something else.

# Roundabout situation cards

## SITUATION Taking an intermediate exit

### 1 · BEFORE

- Read the sign and count exits.
- Check lane arrows before joining.
- Mirrors; normally no approach signal.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Select lane early.
- Reduce to a speed that allows observation.
- Give way to traffic already on the roundabout from the right unless controlled otherwise.

### 3 · DURING

- Stay in lane; follow markings.
- Watch adjacent vehicles and long vehicles.
- After passing the exit before yours: mirrors, then left signal.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Check left side before crossing any lane.
- Exit into the correct lane.
- Cancel signal and build speed.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Treating 'straight' as always left lane

✗ Drifting across lane lines

✗ Late/no exit signal

**GOLDEN RULE** Your lane is chosen by signs and arrows, not by exit number alone.

## SITUATION Taking a right-hand exit

### 1 · BEFORE

- Read sign/markings; identify required lane.
- Interior/right mirror; signal right unless directed otherwise.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Move to lane early and slow progressively.
- Assess signals and traffic from right.

### 3 · DURING

- Hold the correct lane and follow spiral markings.
- After the exit before yours: mirrors, left signal.
- Change lane only when safe.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Do not force across a vehicle on your left.
- Take the safe exit your lane leads to if blocked.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Cutting left across lanes

✗ Following another car instead of markings

✗ Missing left mirror before exit

**GOLDEN RULE** Never trade lane safety for the planned exit.



# Spiral, multi-lane and mini-roundabouts

## Spiral / multi-lane

1. Read the large direction sign.
2. Read arrows painted in your lane.
3. Enter in the correct lane.
4. Follow the lane as it spirals outward.
5. Check left and signal before exit.

## Mini-roundabout

1. Approach slowly and give way to the right.
2. Go around the centre marking, not over it unless vehicle size makes that unavoidable.
3. Avoid signalling so early it misleads at nearby roads.
4. Treat linked mini-roundabouts separately.

### SITUATION You discover you are in the wrong lane

#### 1 · BEFORE

- Keep steering stable.
- Check mirrors and surrounding traffic.

#### 2 · APPROACH

- Do not brake sharply or signal as a demand.
- Assess whether a normal lane change is safely available.

#### 3 · DURING

- If safe: mirror, signal, final check, smooth move.
- If not safe: follow your lane.

#### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Take the exit/direction the lane allows.
- Let the examiner redirect you.

#### COMMON MISTAKES

- ✗ Crossing solid/hatched markings
✗ Forcing between vehicles
✗ Stopping on the roundabout

**GOLDEN RULE** Wrong lane: go safely wrong.

# Lodge Road Roundabout

**Lodge Road Roundabout** is a large, signal-controlled, multi-arm junction connecting the A29 ring-road corridor, A26/Belfast direction, town/Lodge Road and Mountsandel-area movements. Its lane arrangement can vary by approach and may change over time.

## The safe method

1. On approach, identify the destination—not “second exit.”
2. Read overhead/roadside sign and lane arrows.
3. Choose a lane while there is still time.
4. At signals, stop behind the line and preserve the box/exit.
5. Follow the lane line; do not straighten the roundabout.
6. Mirrors and left signal before exiting.

## High-risk moments

- Late lane choice after the arrows begin
- Adjacent traffic cutting across
- Long vehicles using extra width
- Queue blocking the far side
- Green light with no exit space
- Old memorised instructions conflicting with live markings

### Do not memorise a universal Lodge Road lane chart

The correct lane depends on your approach, destination and the live signs/markings. Practise each approach with your ADI and narrate: destination → sign → arrow → lane → exit.

## Practice drill

| Pass                     | Your task                                                                    |
|--------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 · Passenger            | Call out destinations, arrows, lights, lane boundaries and pedestrian areas. |
| 2 · Driver, quiet period | Drive one planned movement with instructor prompts.                          |
| 3 · Driver, independent  | Follow a destination sign; if uncertain, follow the lane safely.             |
| 4 · Debrief              | Sketch only what the current signs showed. Recheck on the next visit.        |

# Other Coleraine roundabout practice

| Practice zone                     | What to rehearse                                                                         | Primary risk                                     |
|-----------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Bushmills Road / A29 corridor     | Early sign reading, lane arrows, approach speed and following the ring-road destination. | Late lane choice and faster traffic.             |
| Ballycastle Road / ring-road area | Roundabout gap judgement, dual/multi-lane positioning, speed-limit transitions.          | Watching one direction and missing nearby users. |
| Strand Road / town approaches     | Urban lanes, lights, crossings, buses and pedestrian planning.                           | Lane fixation and blocked junctions.             |
| Mountsandel / Greenmount areas    | Residential meeting, parked cars, bends, gradients and calm progress.                    | Clearance and poor forward planning.             |
| Gateside / Loughan Hill           | Industrial exits, large vehicles, obscured views and move-off checks.                    | Hidden traffic behind vans/HGVs.                 |

## Local-route evidence

DVA does not publish guaranteed Coleraine routes. These are practice zones named by local route resources and the surrounding road network. Any road may be changed, omitted or temporarily unavailable.

## The roundabout scorecard

- ☐ Destination identified before lane choice
- ☐ Approach mirrors and useful signal
- ☐ Lane selected from live markings
- ☐ Speed allows a genuine right-side assessment
- ☐ Lane held without drift
- ☐ Left mirror before exit signal/movement
- ☐ Exit clear and correct lane maintained

# Lane changes and lane discipline

## SITUATION Changing lane

### 1 · BEFORE

- Ask: is the change needed and legal?
- Interior and target-side mirror.
- Check signs, lane lines and the space ahead.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Match speed to a usable gap.
- Signal if it benefits others.
- Final mirror/sideways check.

### 3 · DURING

- Move gradually; do not steer at the vehicle.
- Maintain speed unless conditions require change.
- Cancel signal.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Rebuild following distance.
- Check mirrors and road ahead.
- Keep left when appropriate.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Signal then assume priority

✗ Moving into a blind spot

✗ Changing near a junction unnecessarily

**GOLDEN RULE** A signal asks; a clear gap permits.

## Blind-spot rule

Mirrors do not show everything. Use an effective sideways glance when needed, especially before moving off, changing lanes or when a cycle/motorcycle could be alongside. Keep it brief so the road ahead is not neglected.

# Dual carriageways: join, drive, leave

## Joining

1. Use the slip road to observe and build a suitable speed.
2. Interior/right mirror; signal if useful.
3. Identify a gap—not a single car.
4. Adjust speed to arrive beside the gap.
5. Final check; merge smoothly.

## Leaving

1. Read signs early and move left in time.
2. Interior/left mirror; signal at the correct marker.
3. Keep speed until established on the slip road, unless signs/traffic require earlier reduction.
4. Brake progressively for the new road.

## On the carriageway

- Keep left unless overtaking or signs/markings direct otherwise.
- Use a following gap of at least two seconds in good dry conditions; increase substantially in rain/poor visibility.
- Before overtaking: mirrors, road ahead, blind spot as needed, legal space and no closing vehicle.
- After overtaking, return left only when safely clear—do not cut in.
- At a reduced limit, be at or below the new limit by the sign.

### No usable gap on a slip road?

Do not force into traffic. Adjust early. If the lane ends and no safe merge exists, you may have to stop, but this makes joining harder—planning and speed matching are essential.

# People, cycles and large vehicles

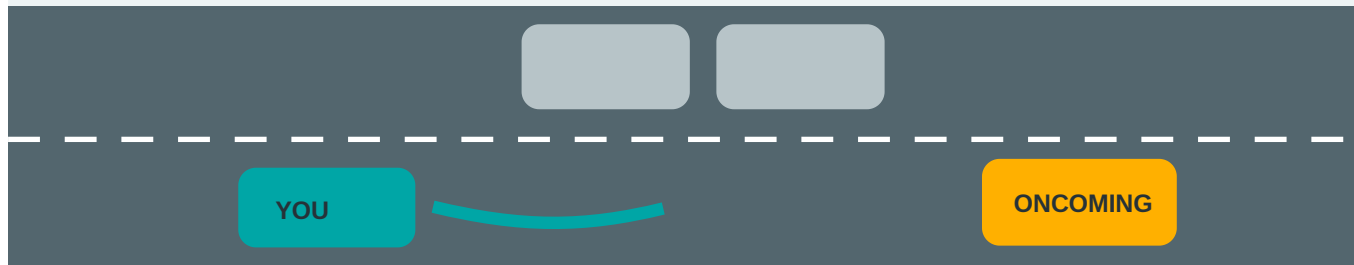
| Hazard                 | Early clue                                               | Safe response                                             |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Pedestrian / child     | Feet under parked cars, school gates, person facing kerb | Ease off, create lateral space, be ready to stop.         |
| Cyclist / motorcyclist | Shoulder check, drain cover, narrowing, filtering        | Hold back; pass only with safe clearance and view.        |
| Bus                    | Indicator, passengers, obscured crossing                 | Let it move when safe; expect people in front/behind.     |
| Large vehicle          | Wide position, trailer cut-in, hidden traffic            | Give room; never enter the space it needs to turn.        |
| Horse / animal         | Warning sign, rider ahead, open gate                     | Slow right down, be quiet, pass wide and patiently.       |
| Emergency vehicle      | Siren/blue lights reflected before seen                  | Plan a legal, safe place; do not cross red or mount kerb. |

## Vulnerable-user test

Ask: "Could they move into my path, and can I stop if they do?" If the answer is uncertain, reduce speed now.

# Parked cars and meeting traffic

YOUR OBSTRUCTION = YOUR RESPONSIBILITY TO WAIT



Leave a door's width where possible; less space means less speed.

## SITUATION Meeting traffic beside parked cars

### 1 · BEFORE

- Scan far ahead for the meeting point.
- Identify whose side is obstructed.
- Check mirrors before changing speed/position.

### 2 · APPROACH

- If obstruction is yours, be prepared to wait.
- Choose a hold-back point with space.
- Avoid squeezing into a narrowing.

### 3 · DURING

- Proceed only if both can pass safely.
- Keep door clearance where possible.
- Reduce speed further as space reduces.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Return left after mirrors when clear.
- Thanking is optional; control comes first.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Racing to the gap

✗ Stopping opposite another parked car

✗ Passing too close to doors

**GOLDEN RULE** Less space means less speed; your obstruction usually means your wait.

# Weather, roadworks and emergencies

## Rain / standing water

- Increase following distance.
- Use dipped headlights if visibility is reduced.
- Brake/steer progressively.
- Avoid deep water if depth is uncertain.

## Fog / glare / night

- Use appropriate lights; fog lights only when visibility is seriously reduced.
- Slow to the visible distance.
- Keep glass clean and demisted.
- Do not stare at oncoming lights.

## Roadworks

- Obey temporary limits/lights.
- Do not “follow through” a red temporary signal.
- Watch workers, cones and changing lanes.
- Merge in turn only where safe and appropriate.

## Emergency vehicle

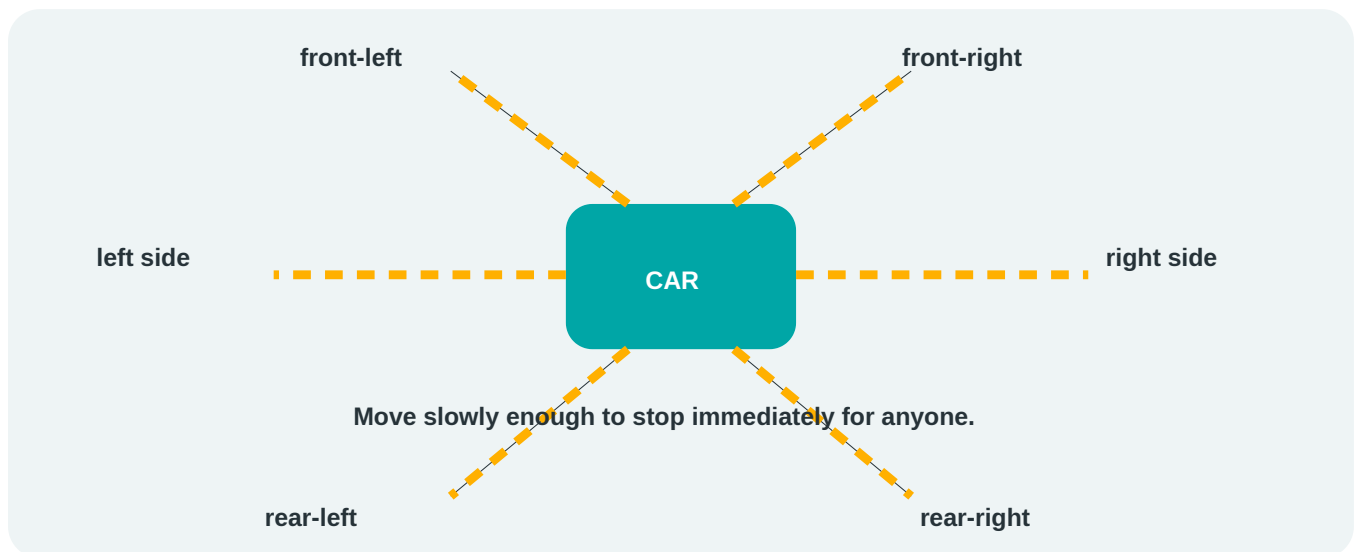
- Check all around and plan.
- Do not panic or brake blindly.
- Do not cross a red light to help.
- Resume only after rechecking.

### Test cancellation

DVA may cancel tests locally in adverse weather. Follow contact details/updates on your booking and allow extra travel time; do not assume cancellation.



# Manoeuvre principles



DVA currently lists one reversing exercise chosen from: **reversing around a corner, turning in the road, or reverse parking on-road or into a parking bay.** The reference points depend on your car and seating position; the safety principles do not.

## Control

Very slow movement, accurate steering, no mounting kerb or loss of control.

## Observation

Continuous all-round checks, with special attention in the direction of travel.

## Judgement

Stop for people/vehicles and resume only after a fresh complete check.

### Correction is allowed

If the position is going wrong, stop, observe, select a safer correction and complete it under control. A calm correction is better than continuing into danger.

# Reverse parking

## SITUATION Reverse parking—road or bay

### 1 · BEFORE

- Confirm the place is legal/suitable.
- All-round observation before moving.
- Set a slow, controllable starting position.

### 3 · DURING

- Steer accurately but keep scanning.
- Pause immediately for anyone approaching.
- Use mirrors as aids—not substitutes for direct observation.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Use the car-specific reference taught by your ADI.
- Select reverse; check all around again.
- Move at walking pace or slower.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Straighten and secure the car.
- Check final position and reasonable spacing.
- Correct only after full observation.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Fixating on one mirror

✗ Moving while a pedestrian approaches

✗ Rushing the final adjustment

**GOLDEN RULE** The car may move only while the whole area remains safe.

### Parallel parking aim

Finish reasonably close and parallel to the kerb, without contact, while controlling the front swing and traffic.

### Bay parking aim

Finish within the bay and under control. Check both sides and protect pedestrians/vehicles behind.

# Corner reverse and turn in the road

## SITUATION Reversing around a corner

### 1 · BEFORE

- Choose a safe, suitable side road.
- Observe all around; check the road you will reverse into.
- Position close and parallel without blocking.

### 3 · DURING

- Steer to follow the kerb without touching it.
- Repeatedly scan front swing, sides and rear.
- Straighten as the car aligns.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Reverse slowly toward the turning point.
- Look mainly through the rear window/direction of travel.
- Pause for any road user.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Finish reasonably close/parallel.
- Stop and secure if instructed.
- Fresh observation before moving away.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Watching only the kerb mirror

✗ Front swinging into traffic

✗ Continuing when another vehicle appears

**GOLDEN RULE** Reverse looking where the car is going; stop whenever the scene changes.

## SITUATION Turning in the road

### 1 · BEFORE

- Assess width, camber, kerbs, driveways and traffic.
- All-round observation.
- Use the full safe width without mounting kerbs.

### 3 · DURING

- Control rollback and front/rear swing.
- Stop for all road users; do not wave them through blindly.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Move slowly; steer briskly when the car moves.
- Observe before every direction change.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Complete facing the opposite direction.
- Straighten, secure, final observation.
- Move off only when safe.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Dry steering

✗ Missing blind-spot checks

✗ Rushing because traffic waits

**GOLDEN RULE** Every direction change needs a new all-round check.

# Moving off safely

## SITUATION Moving off from the kerb

### 1 · BEFORE

- Prepare seat, belt, mirrors and controls.
- Select gear and set a controlled bite/drive.
- Check all around, finishing in the blind spot toward traffic.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Signal only if someone benefits.
- Wait for a safe gap.
- Check again if you have waited.

### 3 · DURING

- Release brake and move smoothly.
- Steer away without swinging wide.
- Build speed appropriately.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Cancel signal.
- Interior mirror check.
- Adopt normal road position.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Mirror-only observation

✗ Signal used as a demand

✗ Moving after the gap has changed

**GOLDEN RULE** Last look, then move—if you wait, look again.

### Uphill

Use sufficient power and clutch/bite control or the automatic-car method taught for your vehicle. Prevent rollback; release parking brake only when ready.

### Behind an obstruction

Observe early; move far enough out to see, but do not emerge into an unsafe gap. Account for the vehicle's front corner.

# Stopping, parking and emergency stop

## SITUATION Pulling up safely at the left

### 1 · BEFORE

- Choose a legal, safe, convenient place.
- Avoid junctions, crossings, driveways and severe bends.
- Interior and left mirror.

### 2 · APPROACH

- Signal if useful.
- Ease left progressively.
- Reduce speed smoothly.

### 3 · DURING

- Keep checking the nearside and kerb.
- Straighten before stopping.
- Finish reasonably close and parallel.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Parking brake; neutral/park as appropriate.
- Cancel signal.
- Secure the vehicle and await instruction.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Stopping too close to junction

✗ Kerb contact

✗ Late harsh braking

**GOLDEN RULE** Choose the place first; then perform the stop.

## SITUATION Emergency stop

### 1 · BEFORE

- Drive normally until instructed.
- Keep both hands ready for firm control.

### 2 · APPROACH

- On signal: react promptly.
- Brake firmly and progressively; clutch at the appropriate point in a manual.
- Keep steering straight and controlled.

### 3 · DURING

- Do not make a routine mirror check before the emergency braking.
- Secure the vehicle after stopping.

### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Before moving again, perform full all-round observation.
- Move only when safe.

### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Delayed reaction

✗ Clutch before brake reducing control

✗ Moving away without observations

**GOLDEN RULE** Stop first; observe before restarting.

# Signs, markings and signals

### Red circles

Mostly prohibitions: speed limit, no entry, width/weight limits. Treat “must not” signs as hard constraints.

### Blue circles

Mostly mandatory directions: turn left, keep left, route for particular users.

### Triangles

Warnings: junction, bend, crossing, school, animals or road condition ahead.

### Rectangles

Information and directions. Read route number, destination and diagram—not colour alone.

### Road arrows

Choose early and stay in lane. A lane arrow can override your generic roundabout plan.

### Lines/hatched areas

Understand broken vs solid boundaries. Do not enter areas bounded by a solid line except where legally permitted.

## Signal discipline

| Good signal                            | Bad signal                                                                  |
|----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Useful, timely, unambiguous, cancelled | Too early near another turn, too late, left running, used to claim priority |

# Crossings, bus lanes and restrictions

| Type                    | Recognition                                     | Driver plan                                                                                             |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Zebra                   | Black/white stripes; flashing beacons           | Approach ready to stop. Give way to pedestrians on the crossing; be alert to those waiting/approaching. |
| Signal-controlled       | Vehicle signals; pedestrian indicators may vary | Obey the vehicle signal. Never proceed because pedestrians appear finished if your light is red.        |
| Toucan / cycle crossing | Pedestrians and cyclists may cross              | Expect faster entry by cycles and check both sides.                                                     |
| School / uncontrolled   | Signs, patrol, refuge or dropped kerb           | Reduce speed and be ready to stop; do not invite someone across without checking all traffic.           |

## Bus/cycle lanes

Read operating times and permitted users. Do not enter a mandatory lane when active; do not stay out of an available lane without reason when it is not active.

## Yellow lines

They regulate waiting, not necessarily loading or stopping in every circumstance. For the test, choose an obviously lawful, safe stop and follow examiner instructions.

### Never wave a pedestrian into hidden danger

Your job is to slow or stop safely. A friendly gesture can be misunderstood by them or by traffic approaching from another direction.

# Coleraine Test Centre

## Official centre

### Coleraine Test Centre

2 Loughan Hill Industrial Estate  
Gateside Road, Loughan Hill  
Coleraine BT52 2NJ

## Immediate environment

Expect an industrial setting: large vehicles, business entrances, parked vans, changing sightlines and people walking between vehicles. Treat this as live traffic, not a “test-centre bubble.”

### SITUATION Leaving the test-centre area

#### 1 · BEFORE

- Set seat/mirrors before being called.
- Know the car’s handbrake, demister and safety controls.
- Observe the car park/yard and exit.

#### 3 · DURING

- Use an effective stop/creep where visibility is blocked.
- Do not let a waiting driver pressure you.

#### 2 · APPROACH

- Move at very low speed.
- Check for pedestrians and reversing vehicles.
- At the road, assess hidden traffic beyond vans/HGVs.

#### 4 · EXIT / FINISH

- Join without affecting road traffic.
- Mirrors, normal position and progress.

#### COMMON MISTAKES

✗ Treating car park as empty

✗ Looking only right

✗ Rushing because test just began

**GOLDEN RULE** The first minute is ordinary driving: slow eyes, calm hands.



# Four Coleraine practice loops

These are **practice loops, not claimed test routes**. Your instructor should adapt them for temporary restrictions, lesson goals and safe legal access. Do not follow this page while driving.

| Loop                    | Areas to combine                                                                  | Skills to score                                                     |
|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A · Industrial → urban  | Loughan Hill/Gateside → Bushmills Road approaches → town streets → return         | Obscured emergence, lights, crossings, lanes, safe stop.            |
| B · Ring-road decisions | Gateside area → A29/Bushmills Road area → Ballycastle Road area → suitable return | Signs, roundabouts, speed transitions, lane discipline.             |
| C · Mixed residential   | Mountsandel/Greenmount streets → major-road turns → Lodge Road vicinity           | Meeting traffic, parked cars, hills, right turns, complex junction. |
| D · Faster-road plan    | Instructor-selected A26/A29 section with safe joining/leaving points              | Acceleration, gaps, following distance, lane change, deceleration.  |

## Score each drive 0–2

**0** needed intervention · **1** safe but prompted/inconsistent · **2** independent and repeatable

- ☐ Observations acted upon
- ☐ Speed appropriate and limits recognised
- ☐ Lane/position planned early
- ☐ Junction gaps safe without undue delay
- ☐ Signals useful and cancelled
- ☐ Clearance from parked/vulnerable users
- ☐ Recovery after a mistake
- ☐ Independent sign reading

# Coleraine risk-area playbook

| Risk area               | Trigger phrase               | Action                                                     |
|-------------------------|------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Blocked Gateside view   | "Hidden road"                | Effective observation; creep only under full control.      |
| Lodge Road approach     | "Destination, arrow, lane"   | Read live information and commit early.                    |
| Ring-road transition    | "New sign, new speed"        | Mirrors, sign check, smooth speed adjustment.              |
| Town crossing           | "Both pavements"             | Ease off and scan each side, including hidden pedestrians. |
| Residential parked cars | "Door, child, meeting point" | Create clearance, reduce speed, decide who waits.          |
| Wrong lane              | "Safely wrong"               | Follow lane unless a fully safe normal change exists.      |

## No "known fail spot" causes a fail by itself

The examiner marks your response to the situation. A difficult junction can be handled well; an apparently easy road can expose poor observation.

# Mistakes and safe recovery

| What happened            | Immediate response                                      | Do not                                 |
|--------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------|
| Missed turn / wrong exit | Continue safely and say so briefly.                     | Brake, reverse or cut across.          |
| Wrong lane               | Follow it unless a normal safe lane change exists.      | Use the signal as a demand.            |
| Stall                    | Secure if needed, neutral, restart, full observation.   | Panic-restart while rolling.           |
| Signalled too early      | Cancel promptly; reassess and signal at the right time. | Continue misleading others.            |
| Hesitated                | Reassess; take the next genuinely safe gap.             | Compensate with a risky gap.           |
| Speed too high           | Mirrors; ease/brake progressively to appropriate speed. | Stare at speedometer or brake blindly. |
| Manoeuvre off line       | Stop, observe, correct slowly.                          | Continue toward kerb/vehicle.          |
| Other driver cuts in     | Create space; avoid conflict.                           | Protect “your right of way.”           |

## When not to correct

Do not correct a navigational mistake if the correction itself is unsafe, illegal or abrupt. Do not reverse after missing a turn. Do not swerve across lane markings. Do not stop where following traffic cannot react.

# Staying calm under pressure

## Before the test

- Normal meal and hydration.
- No last-minute “tour of every route.”
- Arrive as instructed, with margin.
- Use the toilet and silence phone.
- Two slow exhales before entering car.

## During the test

- Listen; ask if unclear.
- Break each instruction into one road at a time.
- At stops, soften grip and breathe.
- After error: stabilise → scan → reset.
- Drive for safety, not examiner approval.

## Useful internal commentary

### “What changes?”

Limit, lane, surface, traffic, visibility?

### “What is hidden?”

Child, cycle, car, crossing, exit?

### “Where can I stop?”

Is my speed compatible with that distance?

### Nerves are not a fault

The examiner assesses the driving they see. You may pause, breathe and ask for an instruction to be repeated. Calm comes from giving yourself time and space.

# Five-second checklists

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## 5-second junction

1. Sign/markings?
2. Mirrors/signal?
3. Position/speed?
4. Right–left–right?
5. Gap + new road clear?

## 5-second roundabout

1. Destination?
2. Sign/arrows?
3. Lane/signal?
4. Speed/give way?
5. Hold lane; mirror-left-exit.

## Move-off

1. Prepare.
2. All round.
3. Blind spot.
4. Signal if useful.
5. Gap still safe? Move.

## Manoeuvre

1. Safe place.
2. All-round check.
3. Very slow.
4. Keep scanning.
5. Stop if scene changes.

**MASTER RULE** If you need more time, create it early with speed—not late with panic.

# Decision tree and examiner language

## “What do I do here?”

1

Is there a  
legal  
instruction?

Light, sign, marking or examiner direction. Obey it unless doing so would be unsafe; examiner directions never override law/signs.

2

Could  
anyone  
enter

If yes/hidden, ease off and prepare to stop.

3

Do I need  
to change  
speed or

Use relevant mirrors, useful signal, safe position.

4

Is the  
space  
definitely

Gap, lane, exit and stopping distance. If not, wait/follow lane.

5

After  
the  
action.

cancel signal, mirrors, normal position and progress.

## Common examiner instructions

| Instruction                                                        | Meaning                                                                 |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| “Follow the road ahead unless signs or markings direct otherwise.” | Continue naturally; read the road. It does not mean ignore lane arrows. |
| “Pull up on the left in a safe place.”                             | You choose the place; take time to avoid restrictions and hazards.      |
| “Take the next road on the right/left.”                            | Use full MSPSL; if unsafe or prohibited, continue and explain.          |
| “Drive on when you are ready.”                                     | No rush: prepare and complete fresh all-round observation.              |

# Final-day cheat sheet

## Night before

- ☐ Documents together
- ☐ Vehicle/legal checks complete
- ☐ Weather and travel checked
- ☐ One short review—not a cram
- ☐ Normal sleep routine

## Before starting

- ☐ Seat, steering, head restraint
- ☐ Seatbelt
- ☐ Mirrors
- ☐ Doors secure / warning lights clear
- ☐ Know demisters and controls
- ☐ One slow exhale

## Top ten reminders

1. Read signs and lane arrows early.
2. Check the mirror that matters, then act on it.
3. Less view or space means less speed.
4. A speed limit is a maximum, not a target.
5. At roundabouts: destination → sign → arrow → lane.
6. Before exiting: interior/left mirror, then left signal.
7. Do not let another driver choose your gap.
8. Wrong lane? Go safely wrong.
9. During reversing, stop whenever the scene changes.
10. One mistake ends when the next safe decision begins.

**FINAL MANTRA**    **SAFE · LEGAL · OBSERVED · UNHURRIED**

# Sources and important limits

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This guide was checked against official Northern Ireland sources available in August 2026. Use these pages to confirm late changes.

1. **About the practical test for cars** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/about-practical-test-cars](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/about-practical-test-cars)
2. **Independent driving** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/independent-driving](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/independent-driving)
3. **Reporting for your practical test** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/reporting-your-practical-test](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/reporting-your-practical-test)
4. **Minimum requirements for test vehicles** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/minimum-requirements-test-vehicles](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/minimum-requirements-test-vehicles)
5. **Vehicle safety questions for car tests** — [nidirect.gov.uk/publications/vehicle-safety-questions-car-tests](https://nidirect.gov.uk/publications/vehicle-safety-questions-car-tests)
6. **Driving and vehicle test centres** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/driving-and-vehicle-test-centres](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/driving-and-vehicle-test-centres)
7. **The Official Highway Code for Northern Ireland** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/highway-code](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/highway-code)
8. **Using the road (rules 159–203), including roundabouts** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/using-road-159-203](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/using-road-159-203)
9. **Speed limits and penalties** — [nidirect.gov.uk/articles/speed-limits-and-penalties-breaking-them](https://nidirect.gov.uk/articles/speed-limits-and-penalties-breaking-them)

## Local information

The official source confirms the centre address. References to likely practice roads come from the surrounding network and third-party route guides; they are not DVA guarantees. Always obey current signs, markings, closures and your instructor.

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Educational summary only. It does not replace the Highway Code, professional instruction, vehicle handbook, appointment letter or legal advice. Diagrams are deliberately schematic and not to scale.